# My Pyramids from Palace of the End

**By Judith Thompson**

## INTRODUCTION

*In 2004, photographs of abuses at Abu Ghraib Detention Center shocked the world. Detainees on leashes, wearing women's undergarments and even posed naked in a human pyramid. Ultimately, seven people were charged for abusive actions, but the face of the scandal will always be Lynndie England, the 21-year-old private grinning at the camera.*

*Private England wasn't the only woman soldier in the photographs - but she was the most arresting looking, like a 14-year-old boy who shouldn't have been there in the first place. Her legal defense, that she was unduly influenced by Specialist Charles Graner, the father of her child and the only soldier still serving time for abuses at Abu Ghraib, was compounded outside the courtroom by assumptions about her background; that she came from a place where people didn't know better - a place called West Virginia.*

*This monologue is the fictionalized account of Pvt Lynndie England – her perceptions, her background and her story. My Pyramids by Judith Thompson from The Palace of the End.*

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**PVT. ENGLAND:** None of them higher ups have spoke to me since it all came crashin down on my head since they moved me here to push around paper; I been waitin on their call but the only person ever calls me is mommy. And my lawyer. He says I am a scapegoat. And he won't let me up on the stand because I won't act like I'm retarded, which is what he wants me to do, so I won't be held accountable; I'll tell the truth. And that is not what anyone wants to hear.

Wonder if I'll be sentenced to jail for eight years like Charley. It's funny, you know, if things had gone different for me, insteada working in an office and waitin for my trial I mighta had a t.v. movie made about me, too. She is truly a hero she is, and hey, did you know she's from

West Virginia too? Yeah, she's a country girl, like me, and us country girls kick butt! Nobody messes with a country girl, oh no, let go! Can you imagine how scared she felt? Everybody in her company killed except her? Prisoner of the most brutal people on earth? Yeah. I reckon Jessica Lynch is America's sweetheart. I am America's secret that got shouted out to the world. And they is not happy about that not at all.

And that is why they gonna make an example of me. But one day, I'mona be in the history books. You wait and see. I'm ona be a War Hero; like Annie Oakley.

I was in that in high school, "Annie Get your Gun." I was one of the chorus singing; our lead was real good, Lisa? She tried for American Idol: "Anything you can do I can do better, I can do anything better 'n you." "I'm just a girl who caint say no, I'm in a terrible twist."

I am going to be remembered. But first, we gotta find a way to somehow, make them pictures disappear. Cause: The thing about those . . . pictures. I . . . look at her, me, that homely little private with the thumbs up. And the naked Iraqi men, and . . . Well, it is like a dream they are telling me I had? But I don't remember it like that? And they are sayin: "No this is the dream you had?" Because they can doctor pictures you know. They can do anything they please. And those forces that do not want Girls in the army – wanted the world to see those pictures.

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Okay, okay, I'mona be honest with you . . in the fact of it . . . That is what I did, for one second they said "give us the thumbs up, baby," so that's what I did. For one second of a whole year, dudes. And that is what everyone sees? How would you like your weirdest second, like, played over and over all over the world . . . for all of time, dude?

Like those dreams about yourself where ya did something WEIRD something you would never do? And ya wake up and ya feel uneasy and you are glad that noboby was lookin in your dream? And ya just wanna forget it and ya do, because dreams, they just disappear, don't they? *(Long beat)*

I'll tell you what most people don't know. It got a hell of a lot worse than that. So what they were naked. So? They get naked every time they have a shower. So? And as far as me laughin at – pointing at the guy's willie? Well tie me down if that's the worst thing that happened to 'em in the Abu G. they be lovin it.

But that is not the style of girl I am, okay? I respect men and their privates and I do not nor have I ever laughed at a man's willie. But these are not men, they are terrorists. And they had intelligence. They knew who was gonna blow up who and as far as I am concerned I was doin' what had to be done, to get to the intelligence and that is, according to their culture, me laughin at their willies was worse than a beatin . . . . way worse. I was softening them up; like you might put out hard butter on the window sill. I had a smile on my face but this was SERIOUS – INTELLIGENCE – WORK.

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And I am very proud to say that the naked human pyramids WAS ALL MY IDEA. Actually, it's the first thing that came to my mind when I walked into that prison and seen all them men that look exactly alike. I know what might be fun: HUMAN PYAMID WITH NIKKID CAPTIVE MEN. Because I always did have an interest in choreography, you know?! I see people dance, I wanna go in an mould 'em.

And they might not have liked it, but they have learned something useful. If they teach gym, in a school. Or supervise a cheerleading squad. We was not entertaining ourselves. We was breaking down the terrorists. And it worked. We did attain information.

And the other . . . Takin the guy around on a leash? Well, he called me a dog. Yes, he did. Just like all you losers on the net. He knew a little English and he called me a dog, so once in my life I could f***in' give it to him. "You think I'm a dog? You think I'm a f***in' dog, you monkey? Let's go for a f***in' walk . . . you wanna go for a walk?" And Charley and them is laughing and well, I never got laughs before. I am not a funny person, and WOW man, getting laughs is the best high. The guys was laughing, dudes, they loved it, so they go: "Put him on the leash." And I do . . . like a sketch, like Saturday Night Live, like . . . oh, my god, it's time to take the dog for a walk . . . Hey, Mom? Did you take the dog for a walk? Henry? Henry? Did you walk the dog? Nobody walked the damn dog. I'm walkin' it. Her dog, ya dirty dog. No treat for you today. You been a bad dog. And I'm pullin' him . . . I was surprised how different is a human neck from a dog neck. With dogs you can pull and pull and they keep on going. Not with humans. They necks is soft.

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And . . . well . . . It is a weird feeling. It made my breathing go a little funny. Shallow. My voice kinda got full of breath. And I felt like I had walked through the looking glass. Where everything was not real and I could walk out again anytime and what was behind there would stay there.

I had that over someone else once and that was – Lee Ann Wibbey. She wanted friends so bad and she smelled and she was weird and ugly? Now she was ugly so nobody liked her. So we was bored so we axed her to come to the clubhouse and she come with her backpack and her nightie – she thought it was a sleepover birthday and we made her strip and bark like a dog, and there was a moment that I realized she would do anything we said. Anything at all. We burned her clothes? And we took her fake leg off, and chopped it up – okay, I know it sounds terrible but we didn't chop up her flesh leg or nothing – and then we tole her to start crawlin home. And we laughed. Oh, my God, we laughed.

Once in church, we hadda think upon our sins, and I seen her there, she was in the church, and she turn around and she looked at me. And I knew then, that what all happened at the clubhouse had been more than a joke for her. Well, sir, I love God and Jesus is my Lord, so I did pray for forgivenessa about Lee Ann Wibby – but dudes, Lee Ann Wibby is an American. She was very VERY different from the APES AT ABU GHRAIB. They was monsters in the shape of human beings. They was prisoners of WAR.

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So, there I was, little me, in ABU GHRAIB . . . me who'd been workin in the Dairy Queen in Fort Ashby, who had been fired from the Dairy Queen for messin up the Brownie Explosion and I was the BIG boss of the BIG DEAL TERRORISTS, guys who had KILLED AMERICANS. GUYS WHO WERE PLANNING ANOTHER 9/11, dud, AND YOU ARE UPSET THAT I laughed AT THEIR WILLIES? *(Beat)*

I will tell you something. We did a hell of a lot worse than what you seen. Or what you heard. What YOU seen is tiddlywinks: we made a man masturbate. Ohhhhh! So SCARY!!! SO? So WHAT? So the frick what? I'll tell you I didn't do nothing to them Iraqis that hadn't been done to me many times at the clubhouse. By my friends, and they still my friends. Yeah. I'm not mad at em, it was just a little fun.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Judith Thompson***
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## AWARD HISTORY

***2013 National Qualifier***
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****NOTE: Nationals and State records did not designate which monologue from A Palace of the End was performed for competition.***

***Cuttings from each monologue: My Pyramids, Harrowdown Hill and Instruments of Yearning are stored in the VAULT for review.***